

The Honourable Society of the Middle Temple

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The Honourable Society of the Middle Temple is one of the four Inns of Court in London, institutions exclusively entitled to call their members to the Bar of England and Wales. Today, it provides support, education and accommodation to barristers at every stage of their careers. Many of the Inn's activities and traditions stretch back to its medieval origins.

The Inn first emerged as a society of lawyers in the mid-fourteenth century, renting land and buildings in the hands of Knights Templar, who had been dissolved in 1312. The Templars had left behind two Halls, the innermost hall by the Temple Church, and one in the middle of the Temple precinct. These two halls gave rise to two Societies of Middle Temple and Inner Temple: communities of lawyers living and working together.

By the early 1400s, the society had begun to take on students in the law, who would undertake a gruelling curriculum, combining lectures, practical exercises, and collegiate dining. By the end of the century, the Inn had coalesced into a well-established and prestigious institution, with distinct traditions and practices.

In the time of Queen Elizabeth I, legal education was not the only form of learning and improvement available for students at the Inn. Young men would hone their skills in dancing, music, conversation and self-promotion, making useful contacts and gaining an understanding of politics and society. The physical location of the Inn was a crucial factor here - located on the edge of the bustling and dynamic City of London, but close to Westminster and the Royal Court.

As admission numbers boomed and the Inn flourished, the antiquated Hall inherited from the Knights Templar was increasingly insufficient, and so construction began on a new Hall, which was completed in 1573 under the auspices of the Treasurer, Edmund Plowden. Plowden was a favourite of Elizabeth I, who is known to have visited the Hall a few years later to inspect the new building.



At the outbreak of the English Civil War, life at the Inn halted, with dining suspended, Readings no longer given and the departure of many senior Royalists. Many activities, particularly the educational curriculum, would struggle to recover after the Restoration of the monarchy. Educational activity thus began stagnation, the curriculum being described by Sir William Blackstone in the early 18th century as “a tedious lonely process”.

The nineteenth century, however, saw a revolution in legal education, with the establishment of the Council of Legal Education in the 1850s and the introduction of innovations such as lectures and compulsory examinations. In 1919, the first woman was admitted to an Inn of Court - Helena Normanton, admitted as a student of Middle Temple on Christmas Eve.

During the Second World War, the Inn suffered damage, including, in October 1940, an attack causing an explosion which ripped a hole in the east gable of the Hall, destroying the wall and smashing the Elizabethan screen and minstrels' gallery to smithereens. Other buildings were destroyed. The Hall was restored by 1949, the occasion celebrated with a grand dinner attended by the King and Queen.

The Inn has boasted many notable members throughout its history, national leaders Edward Akufo-Addo, Lee Kuan Yew and Mia Mottley, writers such as Henry Fielding, Charles Dickens and William Makepeace Thackeray, polymaths Elias Ashmole, John Evelyn.

Today, the Inn continues to provide education and accommodation for lawyers and support its members in their careers. Hall continues to sit at the heart of the Middle Temple's activities, providing a home for its activities as it did when its doors were opened 450 years ago.